

CORE FORMULA

Situation -> Behaviour -> Impact. -> In situation X, I noticed behaviour Y. The impact was Z. -> In this morning's client call, you answered before Priya finished. The client looked unsure who to follow. -> In the review, you flagged the risk early. It saved us a fortnight. -> Best field rule: use the structure to organise thought, then speak like a person.

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Name one specific situation, the observable behaviour you actually saw, and the concrete impact it had — then stop and listen.

BEST FOR

- Specific feedback that needs to be concrete, not a vague impression
- Workplace coaching, supervision and one-to-ones
- Debriefs after a project, incident or client call
- Accountability conversations that must stay fair
- Praise that names exactly what worked and why
- Raising an issue without attacking the person
- Written feedback that has to be scannable

PHRASE BANK

Framing starters · Quick openers

- "Can I give you a quick bit of feedback?"
- "One thing I noticed today, then your take."
- "Mind if I flag something from the meeting?"
- "In situation X, I noticed behaviour Y. The impact was Z."
- "Short version: the timing was the issue, not the idea."
- "Two minutes of feedback, then I'll listen."
- "Quick observation — no drama attached."

Concrete praise · Positive SBI

- "In the review, you flagged the risk early — it saved us a fortnight."
- "When the call went sideways, you stayed calm. It settled the whole room."
- "You rewrote the summary before I asked. It made my morning far easier."
- "In standup you credited Priya's fix. She's been walking taller since."
- "The way you handled that question landed better than anything scripted would have."
- "You stayed late to unblock Sam. It meant we shipped on time."

Work feedback · Coaching and supervision

- "In yesterday's client call, you answered before the brief was finished. The client looked unsure afterwards."
- "During the demo, the screen-share dropped twice. We lost about ten minutes of their attention."
- "In the last two standups the update ran long, and people started drifting before your part."
- "When the deadline moved, I heard it from the client, not from you. It caught me flat-footed."
- "In the report, the numbers and the summary didn't match, so I wasn't sure which to trust."
- "The structure I'm using is just situation, behaviour, impact — tell me if it's off."

Naming the behaviour · Observable, not character

- "The behaviour I'm describing is the interrupting, not you as a person."

- "I'm talking about what happened, not what you meant by it."
- "Here's the specific moment I mean, so we're picturing the same thing."
- "The impact on my side was real, and I wanted you to know."
- "That's the situation and the effect. What's your read?"
- "I'd like that part to change. Can we agree on how?"
- "One clean next step from me, then it's over to you."

Softening and recovering · When it lands wrong

- "I made that too structured — let me say it more simply."
- "That may not be the useful frame. Let me back up."
- "I don't want the structure to override the actual issue."
- "What part of that was useful, and what should we drop?"
- "Let me check whether that's helpful, or if we should come at it another way."
- "I can keep this short, and then we can adjust it together."

Sensitive and charged · Care and high stakes

- "This one's a bit awkward to raise, so bear with me."
- "I want to name something specific, not make it about who you are."
- "Before any feedback — how are you doing with all this?"
- "I might have this wrong. Here's what I saw; tell me what I'm missing."
- "One thing, then I'll stop and hear you out."
- "I'd rather say this plainly than let it sit between us."

Digital and written · Email and message length

- "Situation: the launch email. Behaviour: the link 404'd. Impact: thirty replies asking where to go."
- "Flagging one thing from today so it doesn't get lost."
- "Short note, not a big deal — just want it on your radar."
- "In the doc, the deadline in section 3 contradicts the timeline up top."
- "No need to reply tonight — quick feedback for tomorrow."
- "Two lines: what I saw, and why it matters. Then your call."

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: Using SBI as a visible script, announcing each step and sounding rehearsed.
Better: Using SBI silently to organise a concise, specific response.
Best: Using SBI flexibly, then checking whether the listener is clearer, more heard, and better able to respond.
2. Weak: Naming character or motive: "you were careless".
Better: Naming the behaviour: "the figures weren't checked".
Best: Naming behaviour and impact together: "the figures weren't checked, so we sent the wrong total".
3. Weak: Leaving the impact vague: "it wasn't great".
Better: Naming a concrete impact: "we lost ten minutes".
Best: Naming the impact, then pausing to let them respond before you fill the silence.

DECISION TREE

If They need it fast

Use the shortest SBI — one line per step, no preamble.
"Quick one: in the call, you cut in early, and the client hesitated."

If Emotion is running high

Validate first and delay the framework until they feel heard.
"Before anything structured — that sounded like a rough week."

If They need a story or context, not a verdict

Switch to an example-led neighbour like STAR or CARL.
"Let me walk you through what actually happened, start to finish."

If They need to act

End with one clean next step, not more analysis.

"So the one change from here: loop me in before the client does."

If They look confused by the structure

Summarise in plain words and invite correction.

"Simplest version: the timing was the issue. Have I got that right?"

SCENARIOS

Work meeting

Make the contribution concise and memorable with one clean SBI line. — "In the planning session, the estimate doubled with no note. It's made the timeline hard to trust."

Written feedback or email

Put each step in a short labelled line so the reader can scan it. — "Situation: the launch email. Behaviour: the link 404'd. Impact: about thirty replies asking where to go."

Giving praise

Name the exact behaviour and its effect so it doesn't read as flattery. — "In the retro, you owned the miss straight away. It made it safe for everyone else to be honest."

A difficult one-to-one

One sentence per step, then pause and let them respond. — "In Thursday's review, the feedback came across as personal. A couple of people went quiet after."

Coaching a repeat issue

Tie the behaviour to the pattern, not a single slip, then agree a next step. — "This is the third sprint the demo has overrun. It's eating into the client's questions each time."

High emotion or power imbalance

Validate first, keep the structure light, and hand control back at the end. — "This might be hard to hear — I'll say what I saw, then it's over to you."

WHEN NOT TO USE

- Fresh conflict where emotion is still running high
- Shame-heavy conversations that need warmth before structure
- Vague impressions you cannot tie to an observable behaviour
- Moments where you cannot name a specific situation
- Power imbalance, distress, grief or anger — slow down first
- High-stakes decisions that need discussion, not a verdict
- When physical safety or an emergency takes priority

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Spot the three parts

Take a piece of feedback you'd normally give and split it on paper into Situation, Behaviour and Impact.

Day 2 — Strip out character

Rewrite each Behaviour line so it names only what was observable — no motive, no "lazy", "careless" or "didn't care".

Day 3 — Make the impact concrete

Replace every vague impact ("it wasn't great") with something specific: time lost, confusion caused, trust affected.

Day 4 — Write it in 60 seconds

Draft a full SBI response you could say aloud in about a minute, then cut it by a third without losing the point.

Day 5 — Say it two ways

Say it once as visible structure and once as plain human speech. Keep the version that sounds like you.

Day 6 — Use it for praise

Give one real piece of positive feedback with SBI — name the exact behaviour and the effect it had.

Day 7 — Use it live, then calibrate

In a real conversation, deliver one SBI, pause, and check whether the person is clearer. Adapt if they're not.

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I use SBI to serve the listener, not to sound polished?
- Was the situation specific enough that they knew the exact moment?
- Did I describe observable behaviour, not character or motive?
- Was the impact concrete rather than vague?
- Did I pause and adapt when the listener needed something else?
- Did I preserve their autonomy and dignity?